Install Kali Linux in VMware Workstation Pro

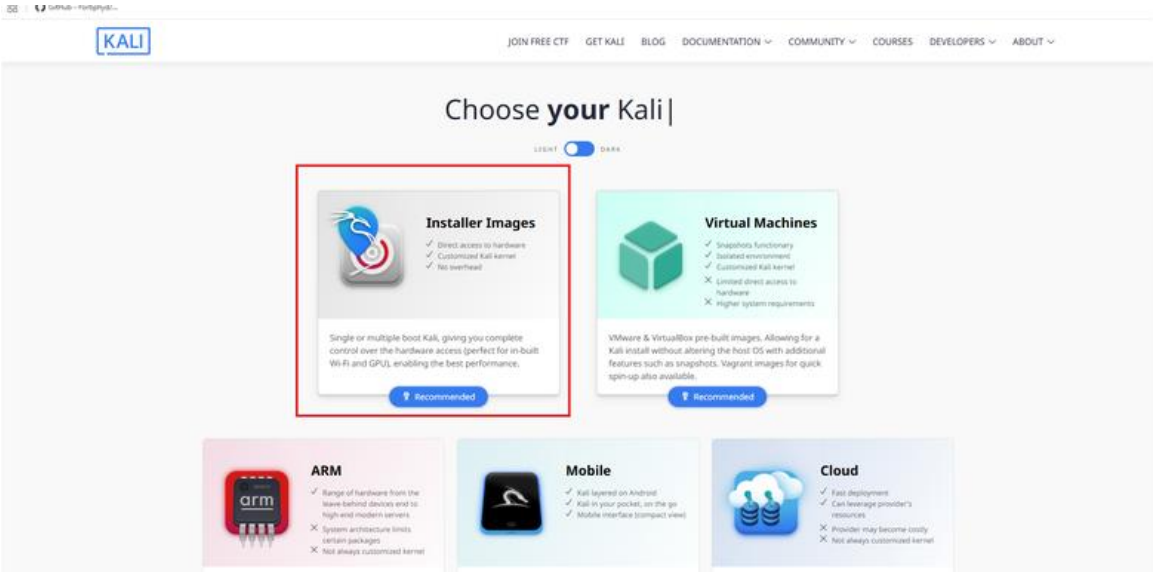
A step-by-step guide: download Kali Linux 2025.4, create a virtual machine and complete the graphical installation.

Requirements	
Hypervisor	VMware Workstation Pro (25H2)
ISO	Kali Linux 2025.4 Installer (x86_64, or ARM64 for Apple Silicon)
Recommended VM	4 GB RAM, 4 CPU cores, 50 GB disk
Steps	32 steps in 4 parts

Part 1 - Download Kali Linux

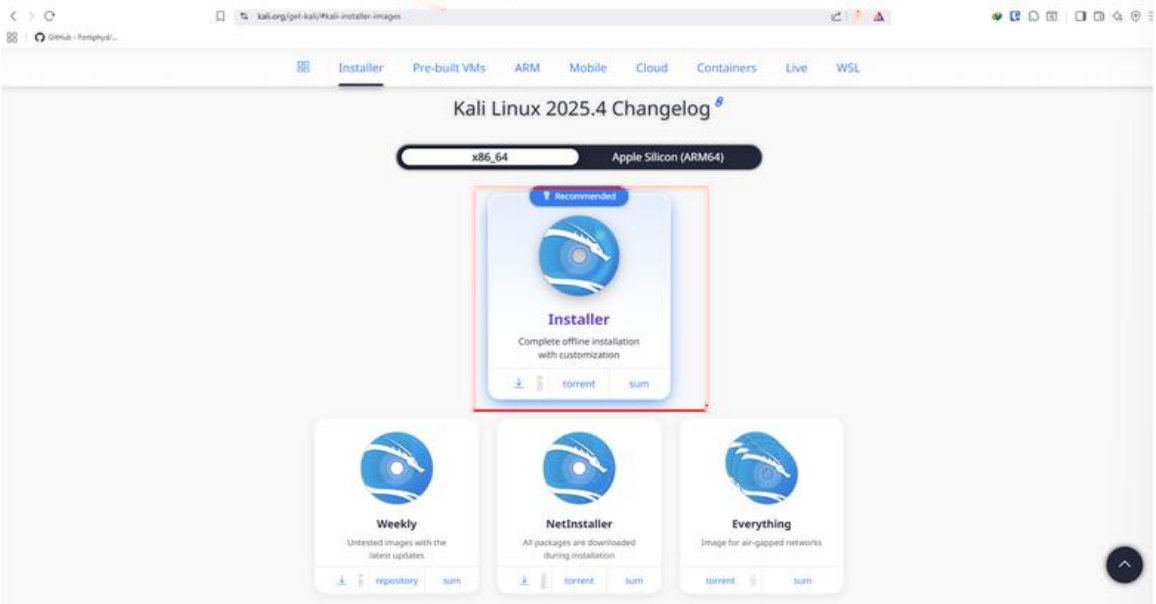
Step 1: Open the official download page

Go to the official Kali website (https://www.kali.org/get-kali/) and choose **Installer Images**. Always download from the vendor site.



Step 2: Download the installer ISO

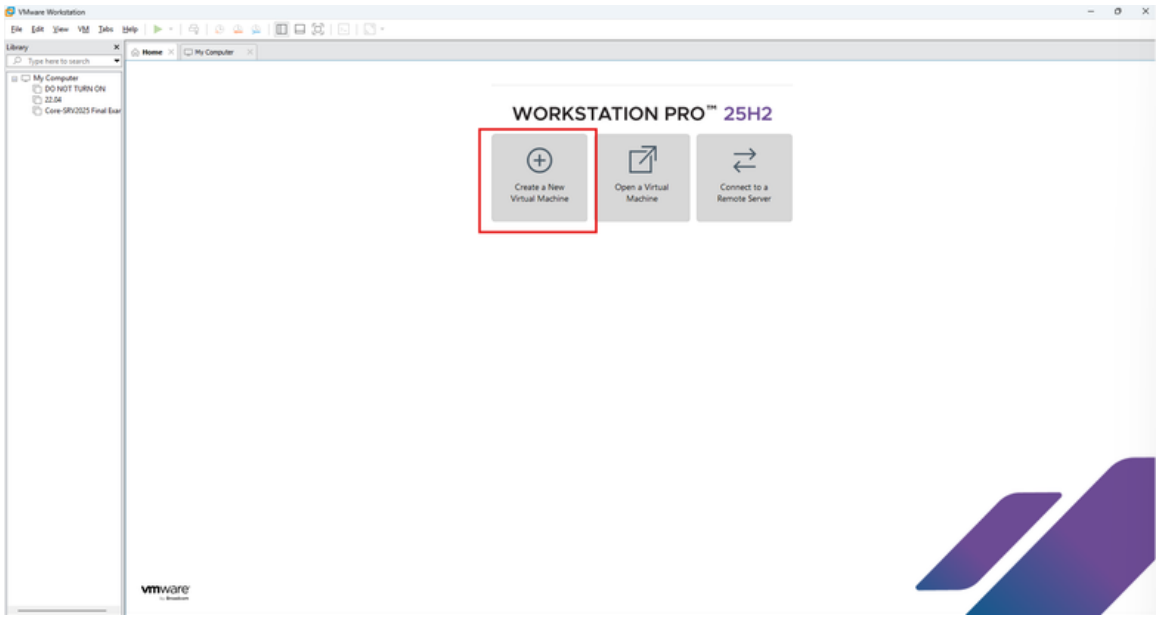
Select **Kali Linux 2025.4** and the **x86_64** tab, then click the download icon on the **Installer** card. **Note:** if you use a MacBook with an Apple M-series chip (M1, M2, M3, M4), select **Apple Silicon (ARM64)** instead. Optionally use the *sum* link to verify the file checksum.



Part 2 - Create the Virtual Machine in VMware Workstation Pro

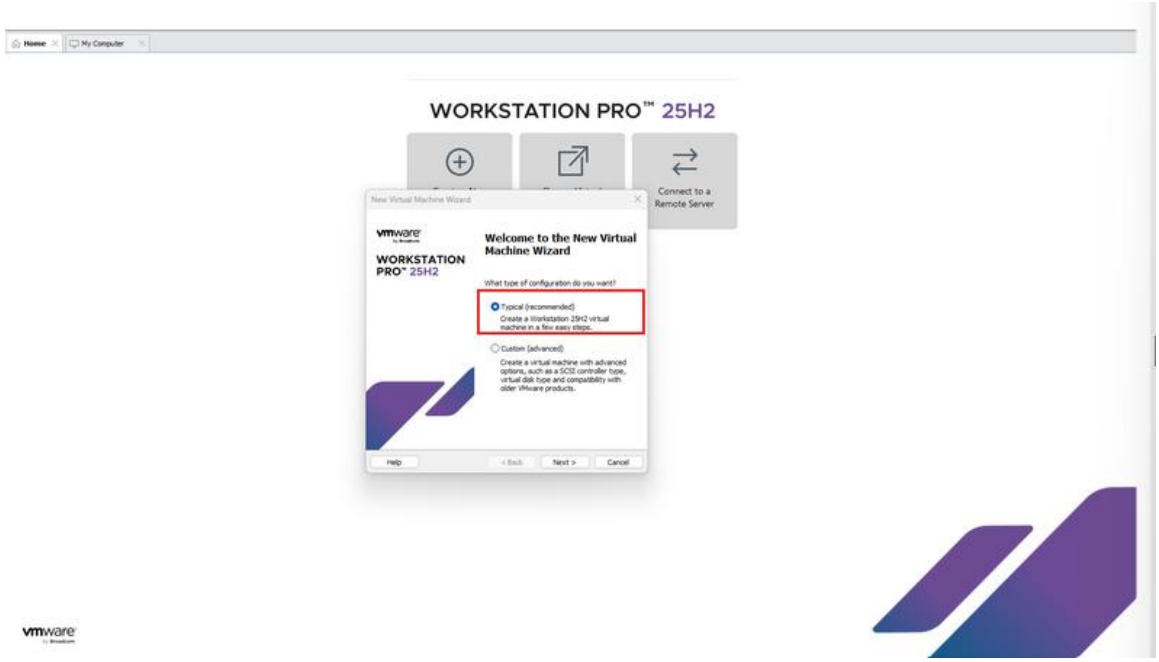
Step 3: Create a new virtual machine

When the download is complete, open VMware Workstation Pro and click **Create a New Virtual Machine**. Because this is a VM, you can delete, re-create or modify it at any time without affecting the host system.



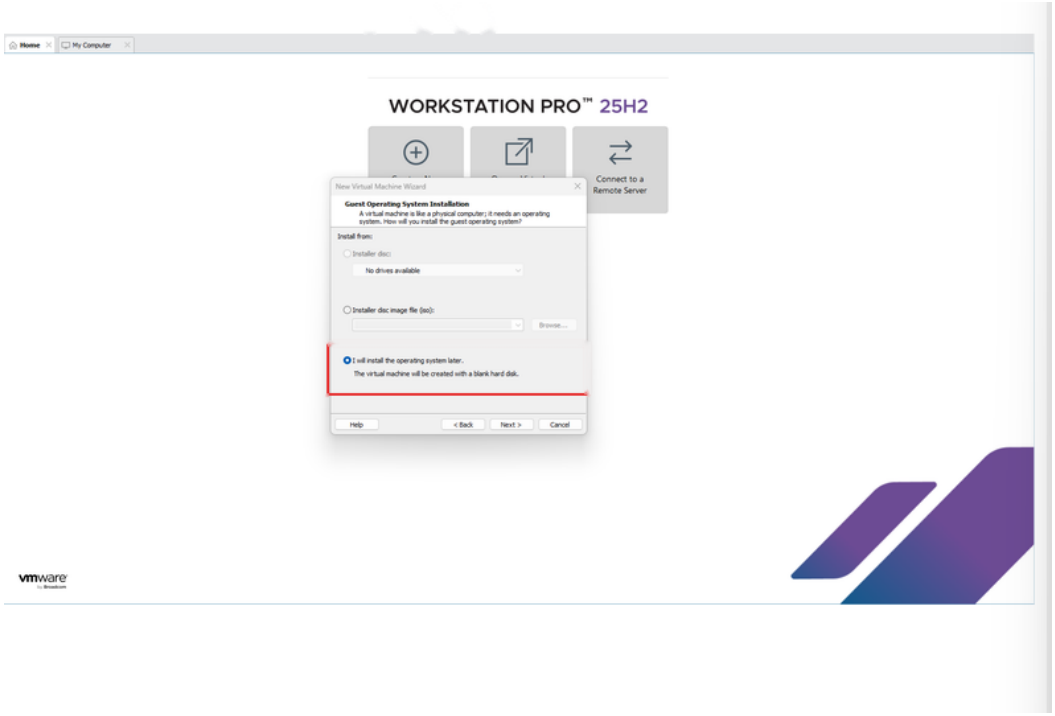
Step 4: Choose the Typical configuration

In the New Virtual Machine Wizard, select **Typical (recommended)** and click **Next**.



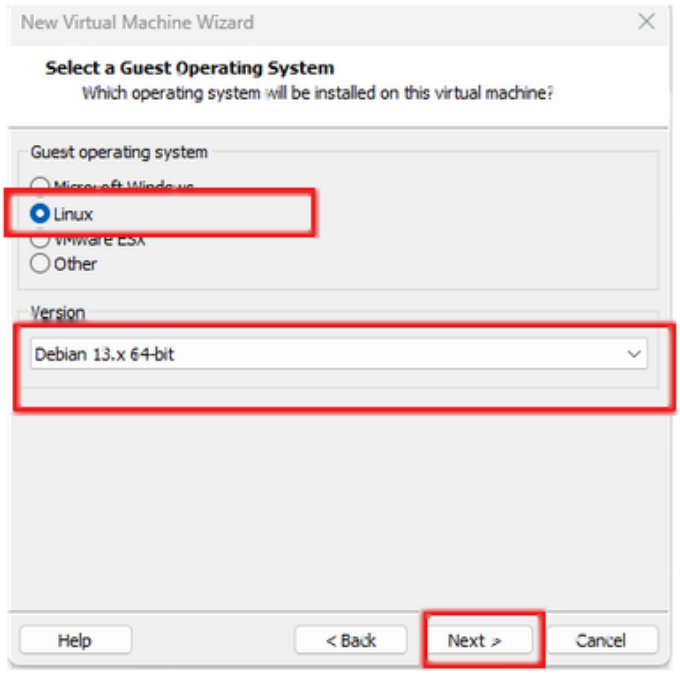
Step 5: Install the operating system later

Select **I will install the operating system later**. This gives you the flexibility to adjust the system settings before the Kali machine is created. Click **Next**.



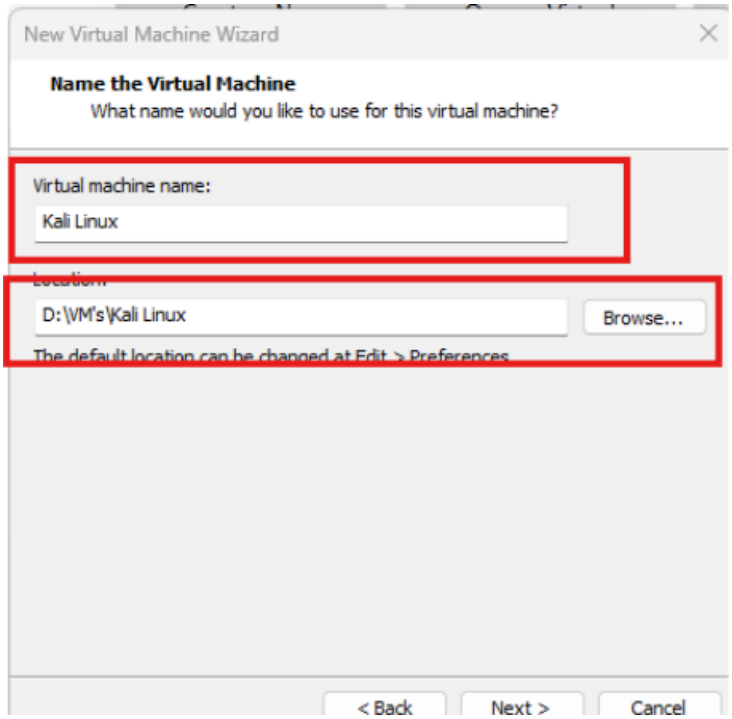
Step 6: Select the guest operating system

Select **Linux** and set the version to **Debian 13.x 64-bit** (Kali Linux is a Debian-based distribution). Click **Next**.



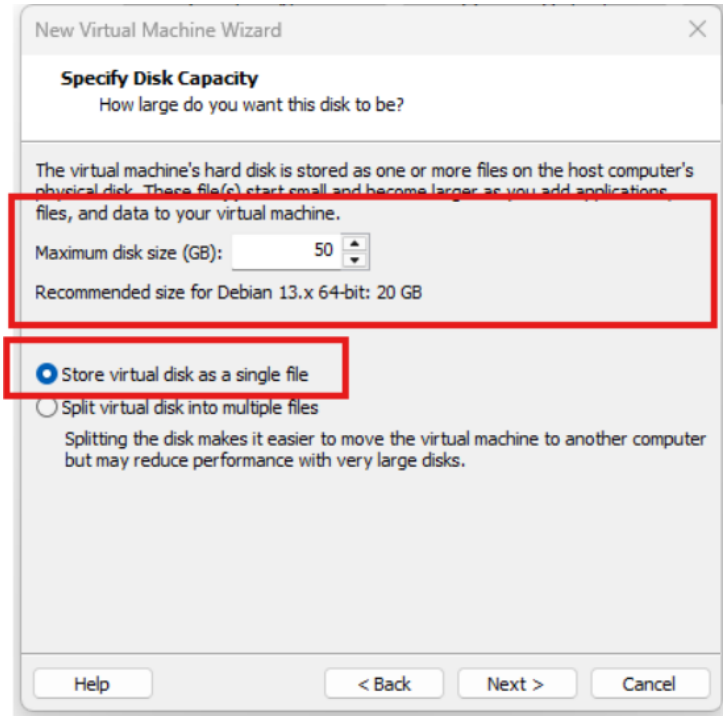
Step 7: Name the virtual machine

Enter a name (for example **Kali Linux**) and choose where the VM files will be stored. Click **Next**.



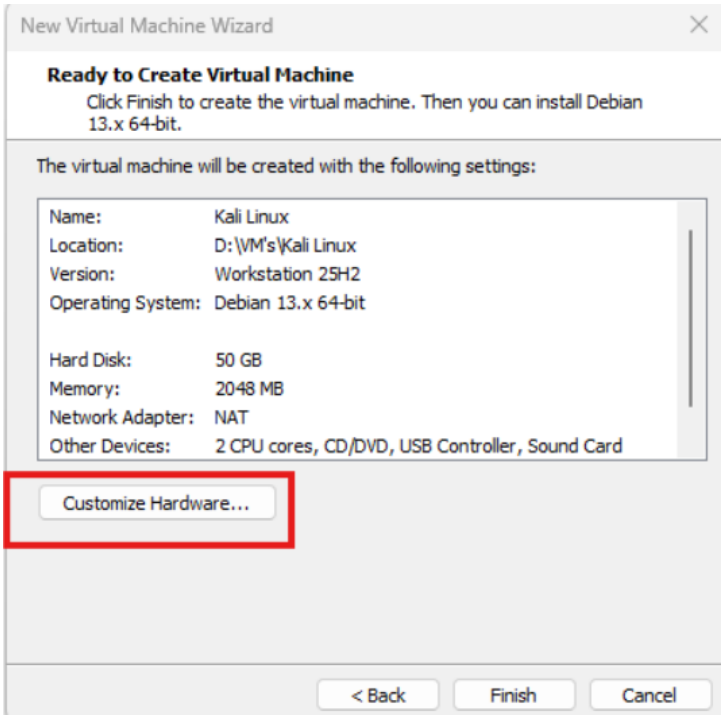
Step 8: Specify the disk capacity

Set the maximum disk size to **50 GB** (the recommended minimum for Debian 13.x is 20 GB) and choose **Store virtual disk as a single file**. Click **Next**.



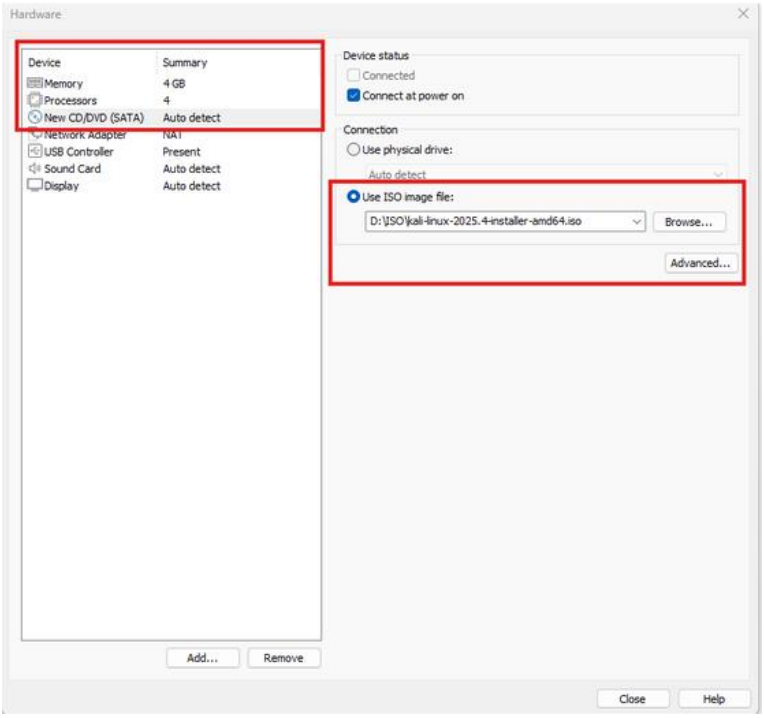
Step 9: Open Customize Hardware

On the *Ready to Create Virtual Machine* page the defaults are 2048 MB of memory and 2 CPU cores. Click **Customize Hardware...** to change them.



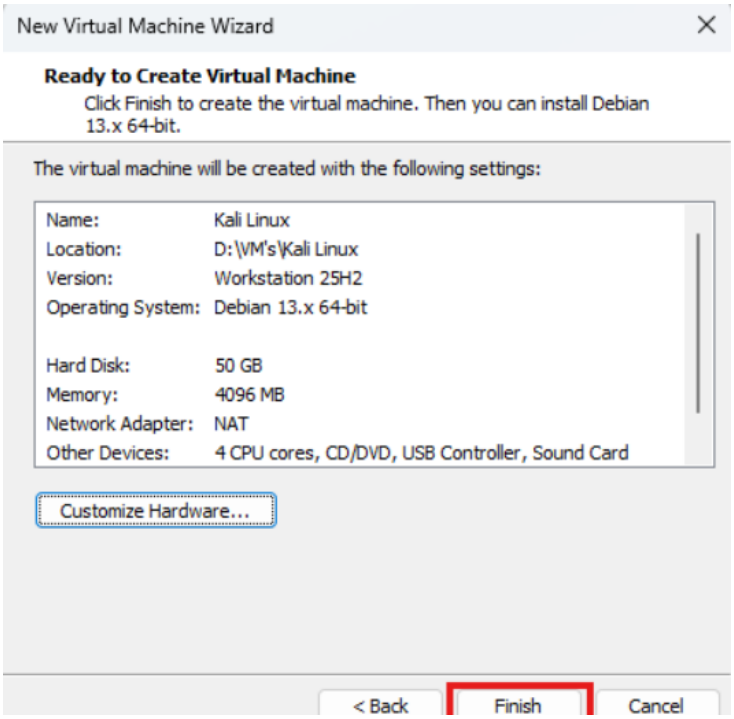
Step 10: Adjust memory, processors and attach the ISO

Set **Memory to 4 GB** and **Processors to 4**. Select **New CD/DVD (SATA)**, choose **Use ISO image file** and browse to the downloaded kali-linux-2025.4-installer-amd64.iso. Click **Close**.



Step 11: Finish creating the VM

The summary now shows 4096 MB memory and 4 CPU cores. Click **Finish**.



Step 12: Power on the virtual machine

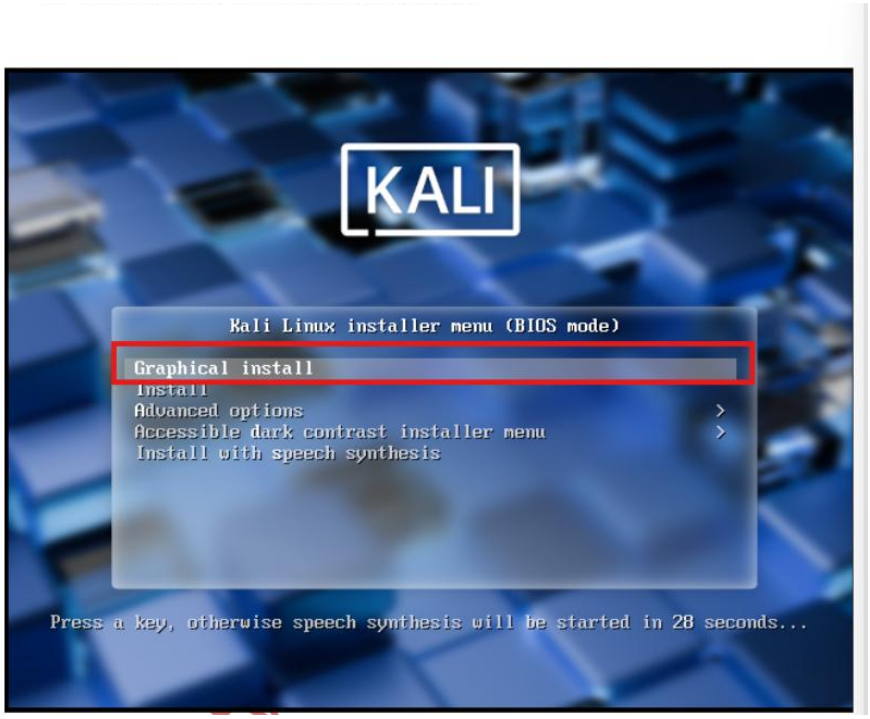
Click **Power on this virtual machine** to boot from the Kali installer ISO.



Part 3 - Install Kali Linux

Step 13: Start the graphical installer

In the Kali installer boot menu, select **Graphical install** and press **Enter**.



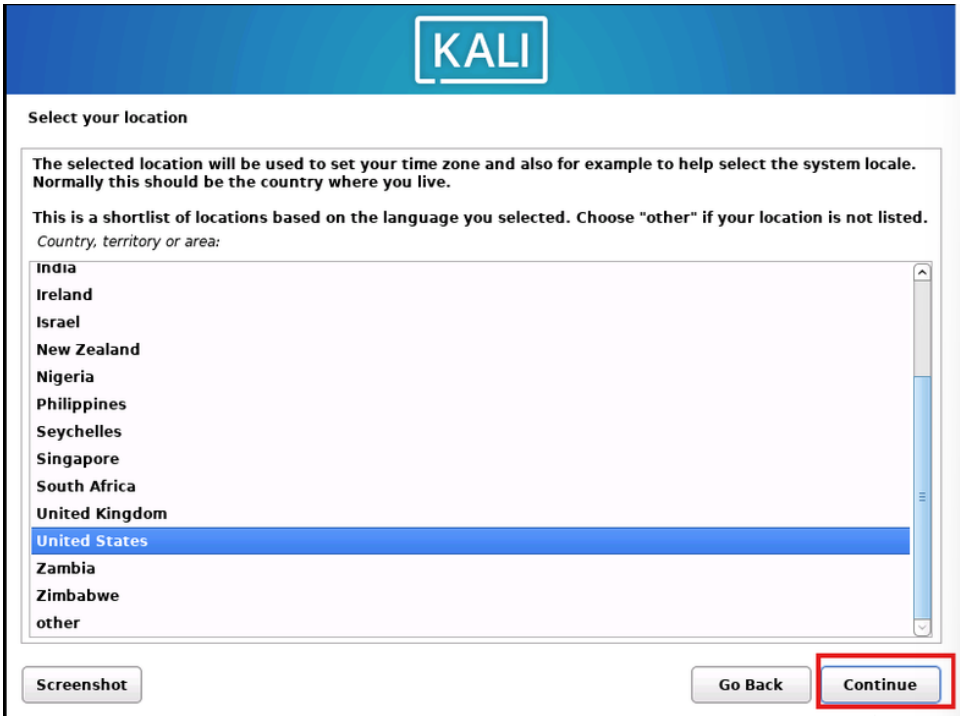
Step 14: Select the language

Choose **English** and click **Continue**.



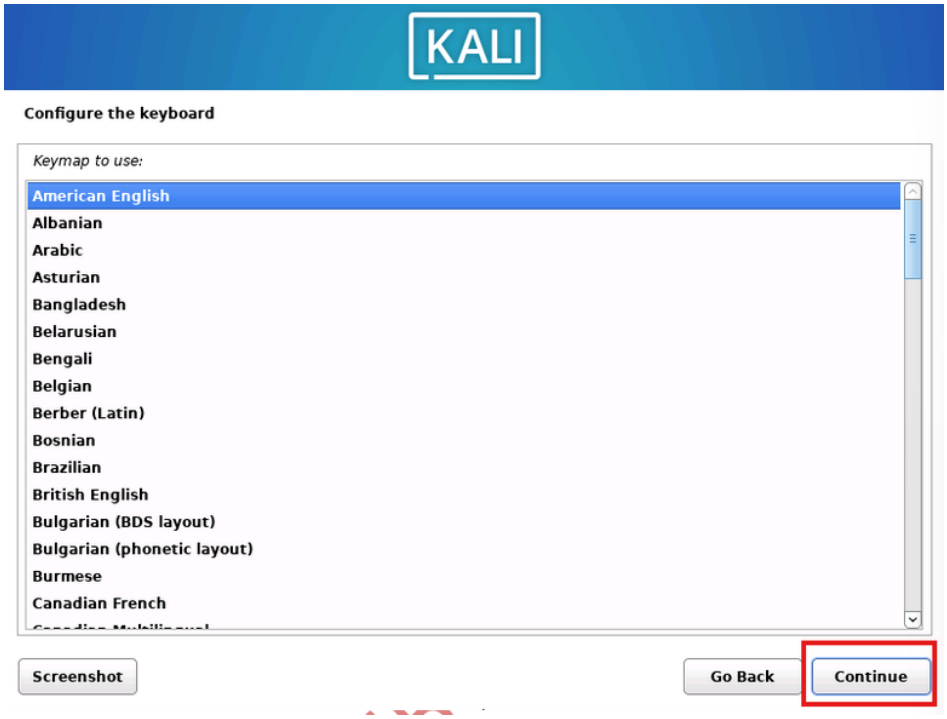
Step 15: Select your location

Choose your country. The screenshot uses **United States**; pick the country where you live, because it sets the time zone and locale. Click **Continue**.



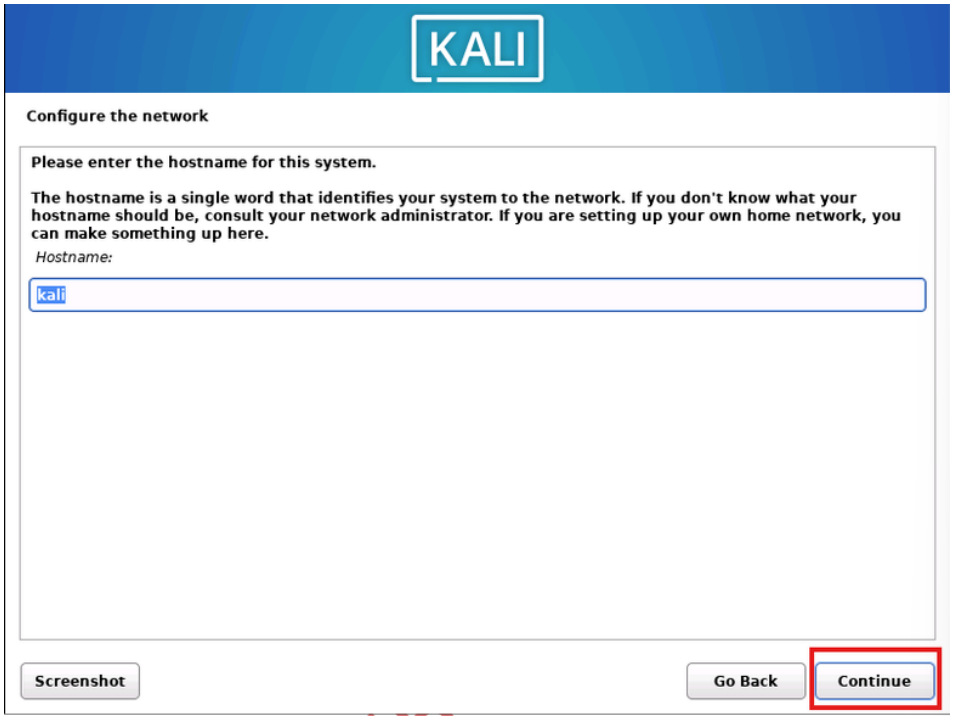
Step 16: Configure the keyboard

Select the keymap you use (**American English** here) and click **Continue**.



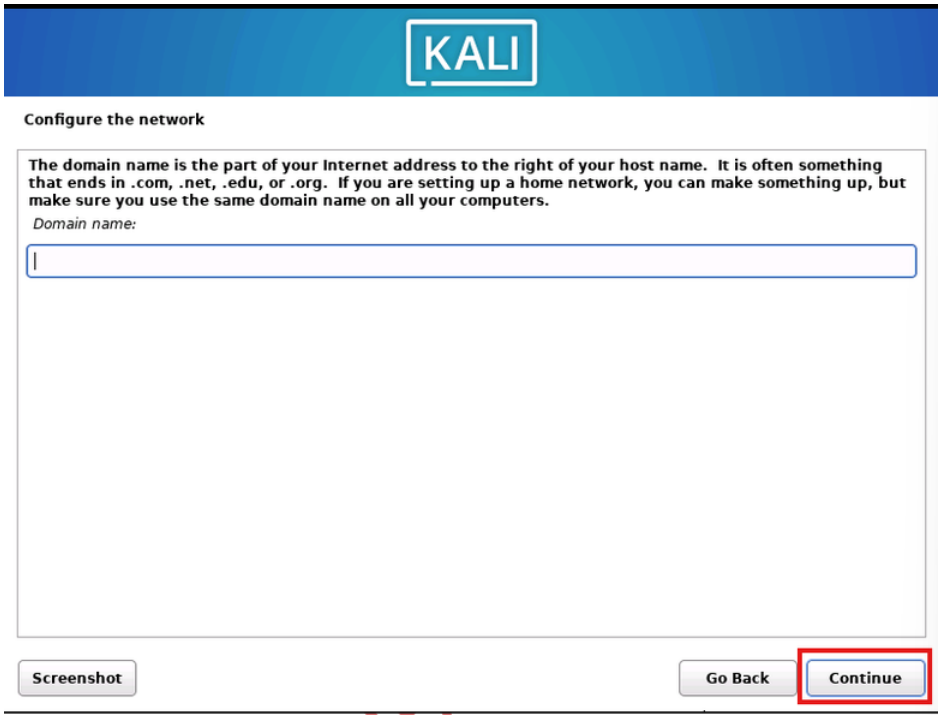
Step 17: Set the hostname

Keep the default hostname kali or enter your own, then click **Continue**.



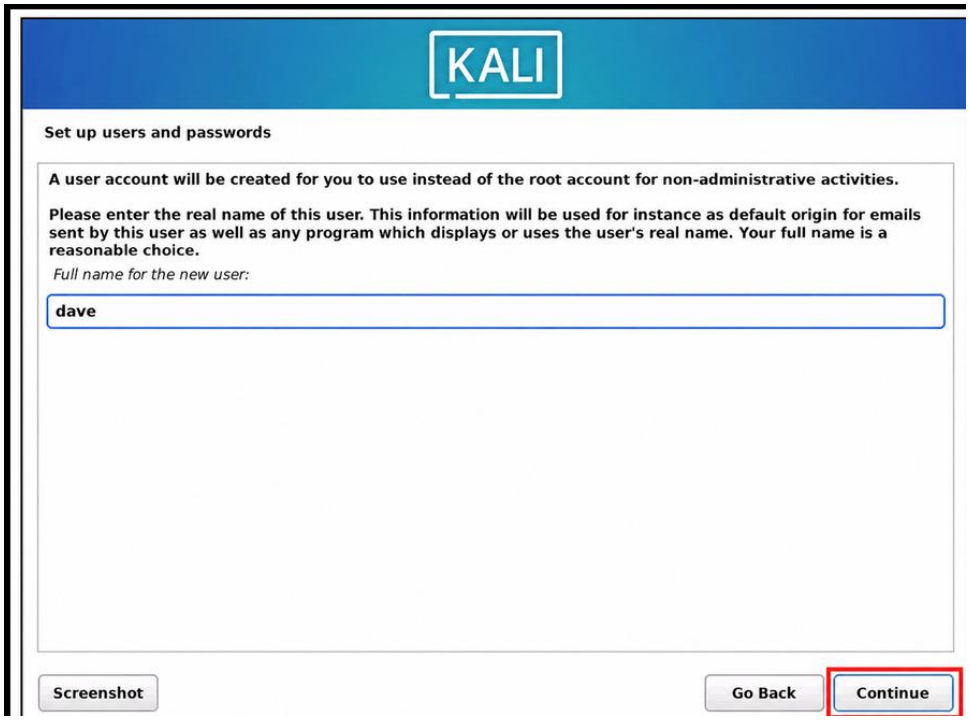
Step 18: Set the domain name

Leave the domain name empty for a home or lab setup and click **Continue**.



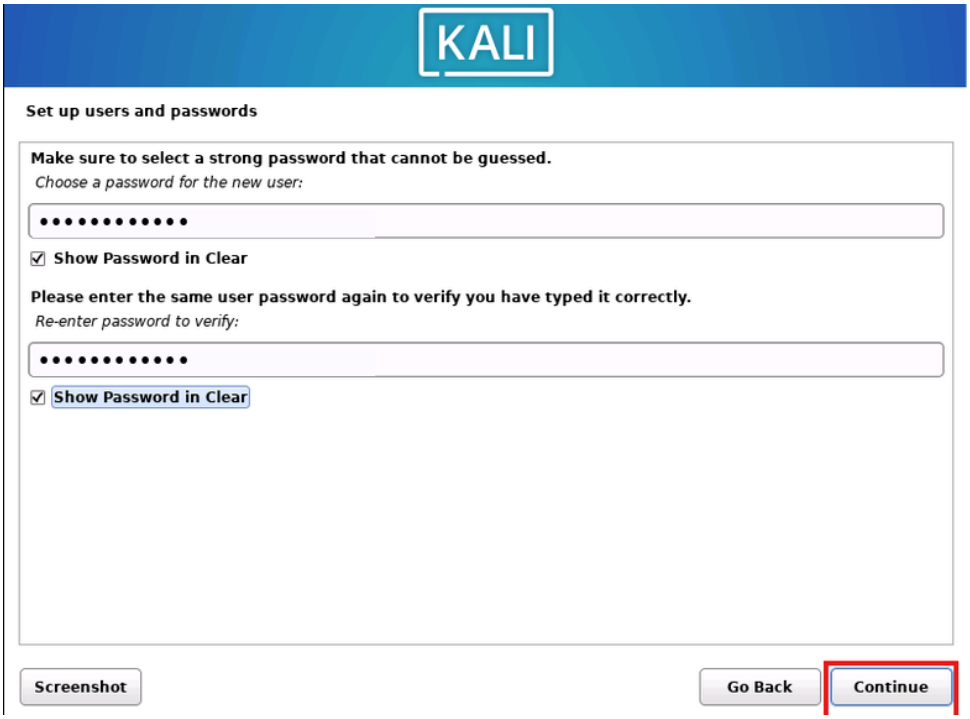
Step 19: Enter the user's full name

Enter the real name for the new non-root user and click **Continue**. The installer will then ask for a **username** (it suggests one based on the full name); accept it or enter your own and click **Continue**.



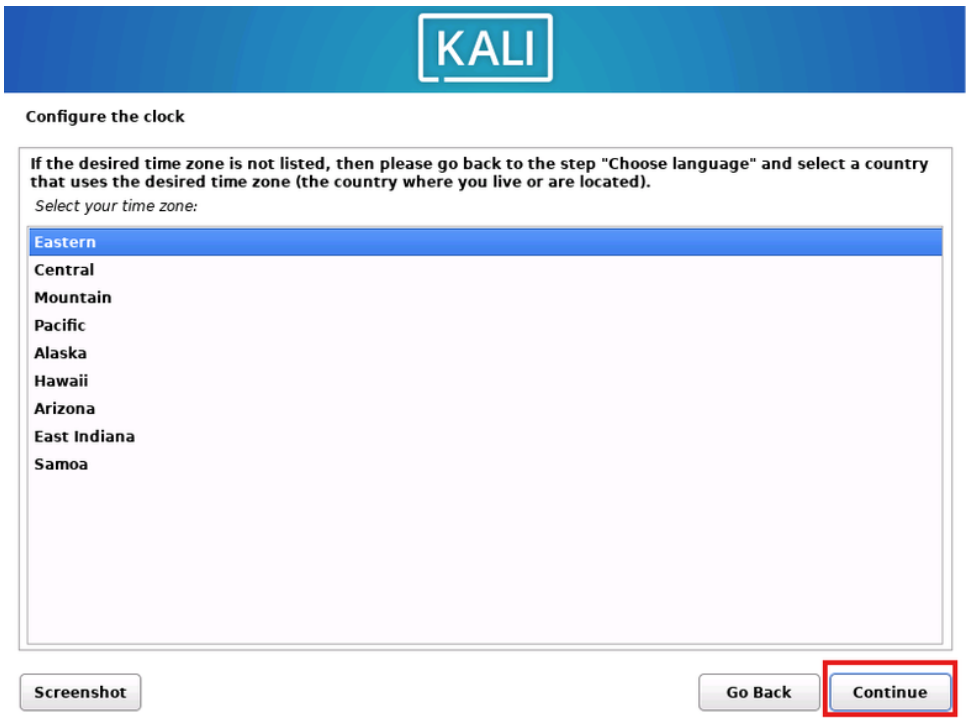
Step 20: Choose a password

Enter a strong password, re-enter it to verify, and click **Continue**. **Security note:** the password shown in the original lab was a weak example and is masked here - never reuse it; choose a unique password of your own.



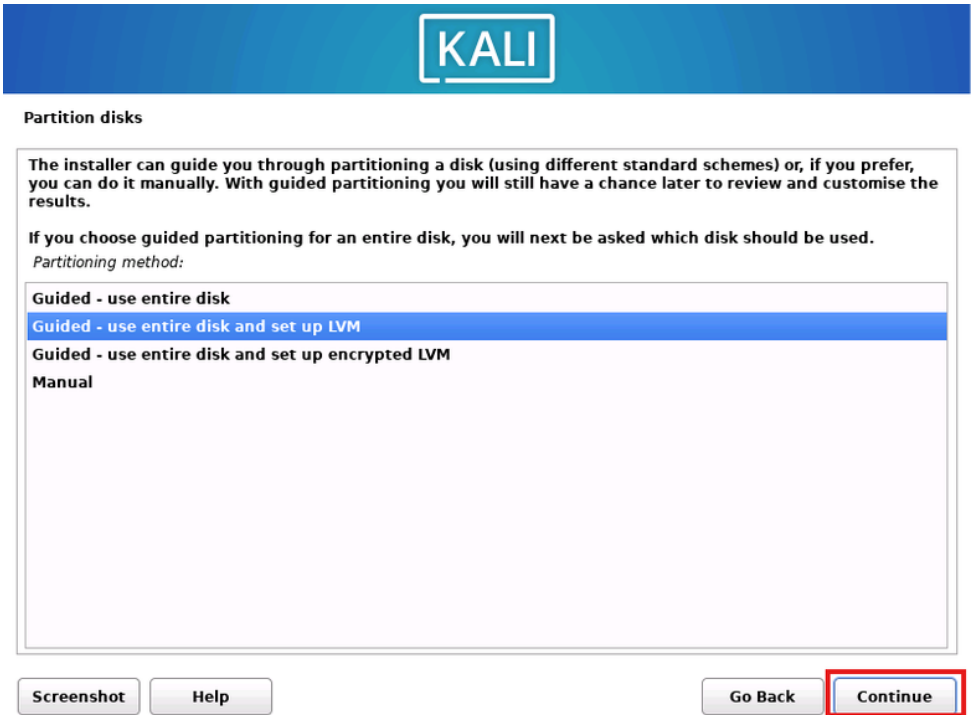
Step 21: Configure the clock

Select your time zone and click **Continue**.



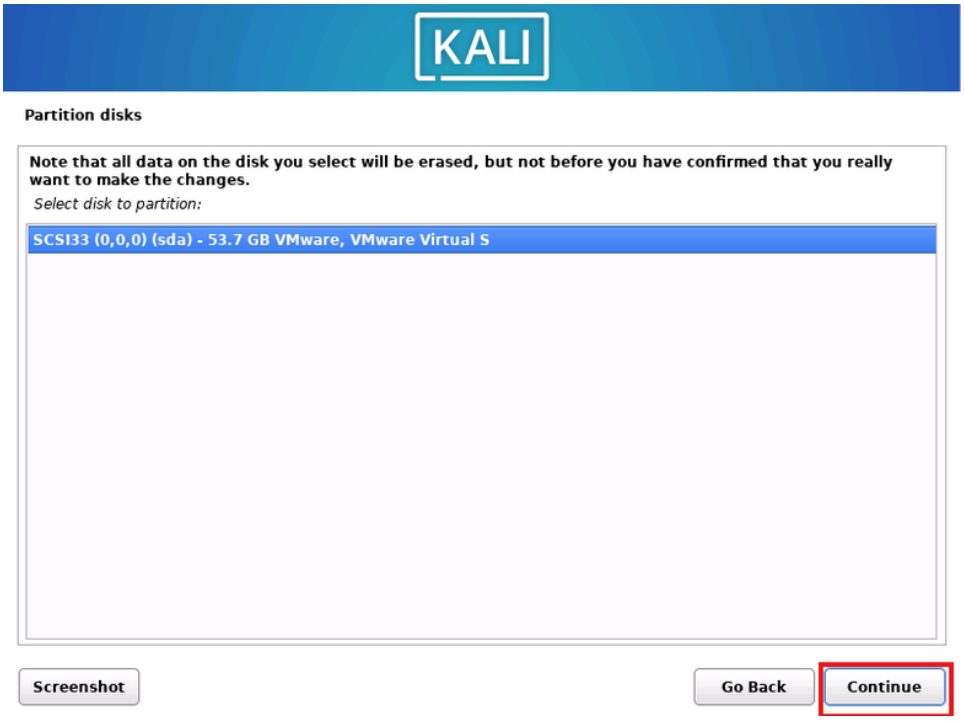
Step 22: Choose the partitioning method

Select **Guided - use entire disk and set up LVM** and click **Continue**. This only affects the virtual disk, not your real computer.



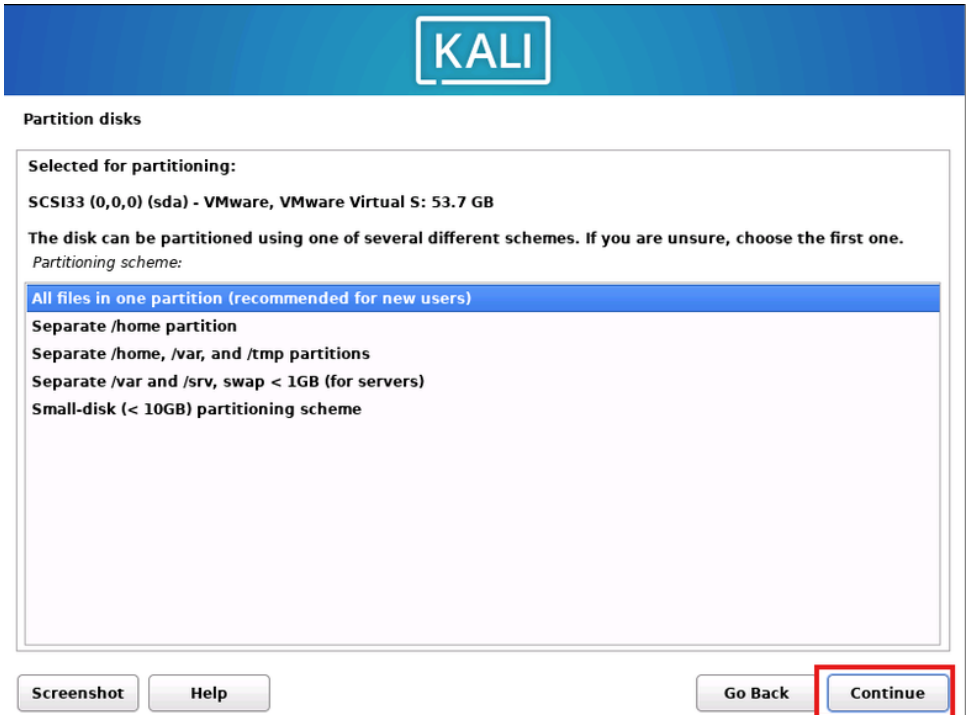
Step 23: Select the disk to partition

Select the single virtual disk (sda, about 53.7 GB) and click **Continue**.



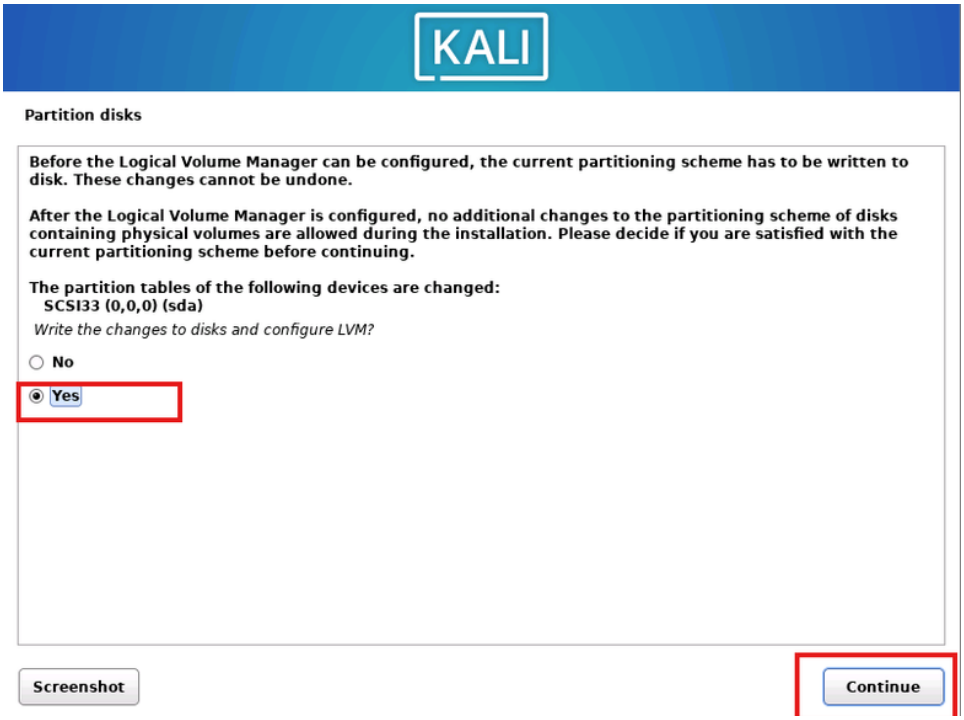
Step 24: Choose the partitioning scheme

Select **All files in one partition (recommended for new users)** and click **Continue**.



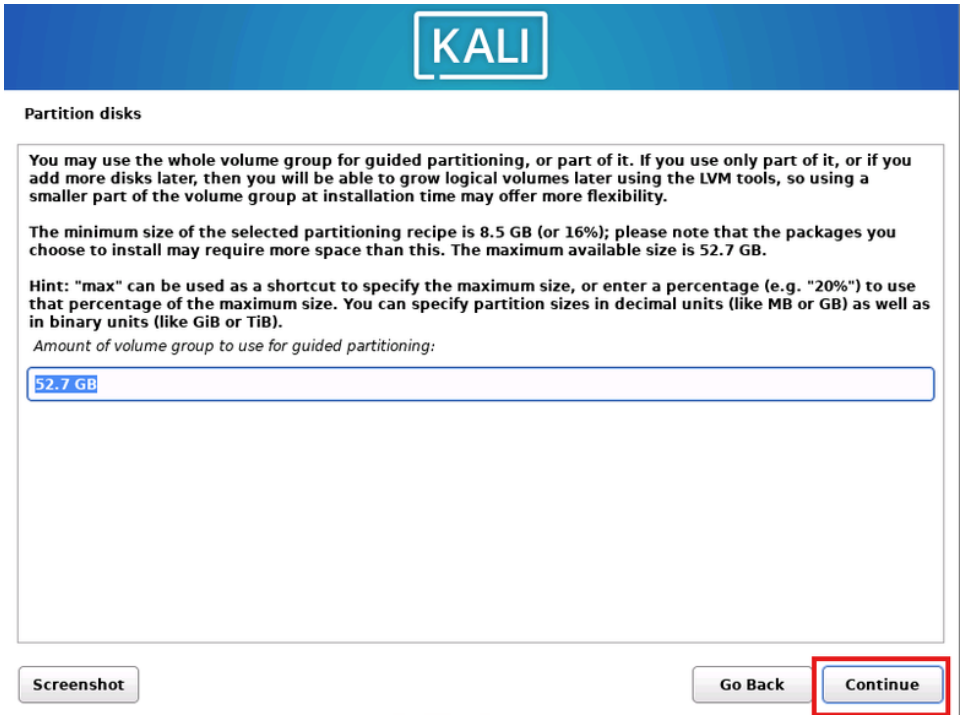
Step 25: Write the changes and configure LVM

Select **Yes** and click **Continue**.



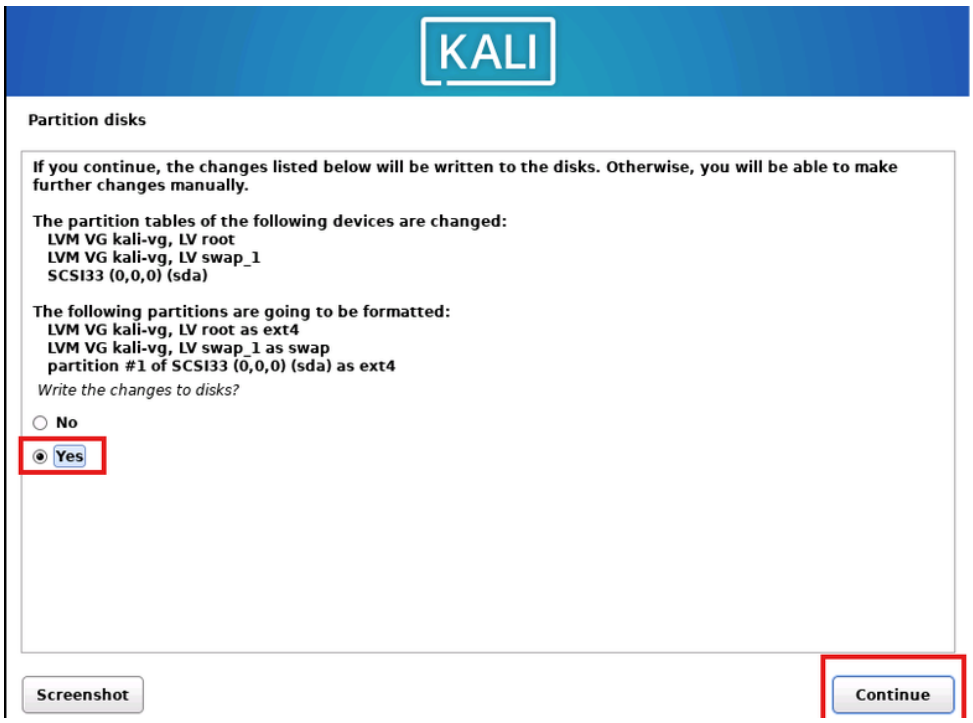
Step 26: Set the volume group size

Keep the maximum value (about 52.7 GB) and click **Continue**.



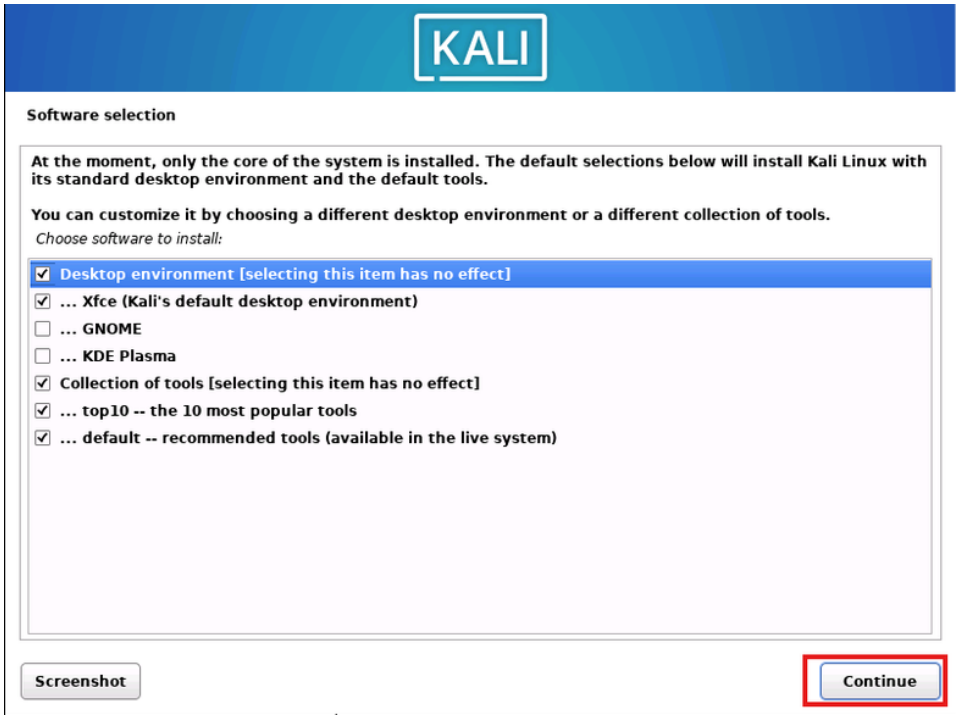
Step 27: Confirm writing the partitions

Review the summary, select **Yes** to write the changes to disk and click **Continue**. The base system is then installed.



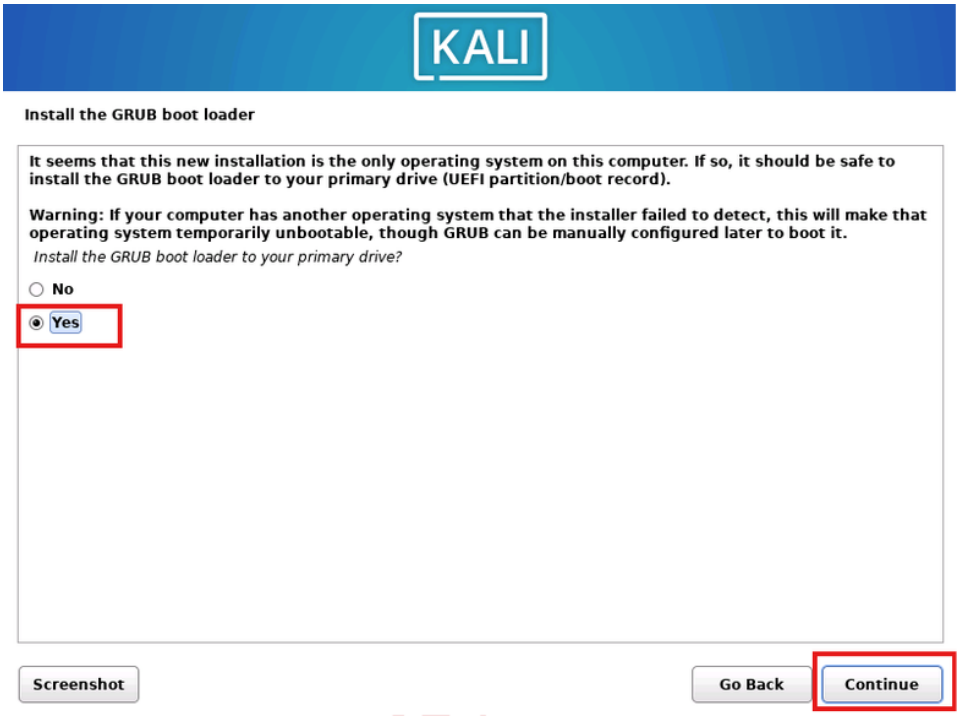
Step 28: Select the software to install

Keep the defaults - **Xfce** desktop environment plus the **top10** and **default** tool collections - and click **Continue**. This is why Kali is used for security work: it ships hundreds of ready-to-use security tools.



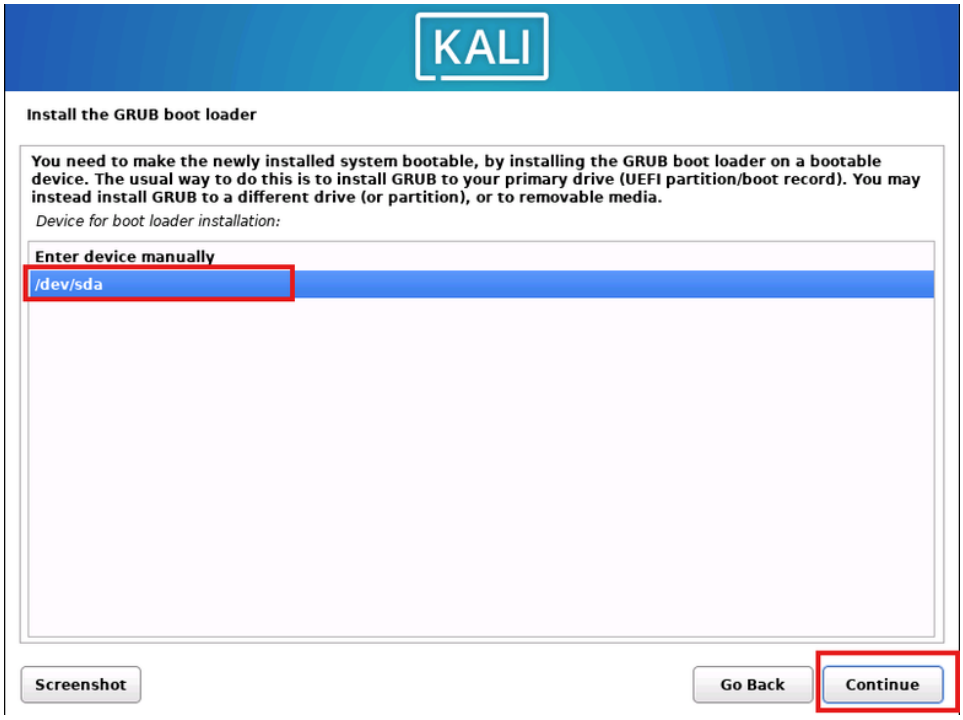
Step 29: Install the GRUB boot loader

Select **Yes** to install GRUB to the primary drive and click **Continue**.



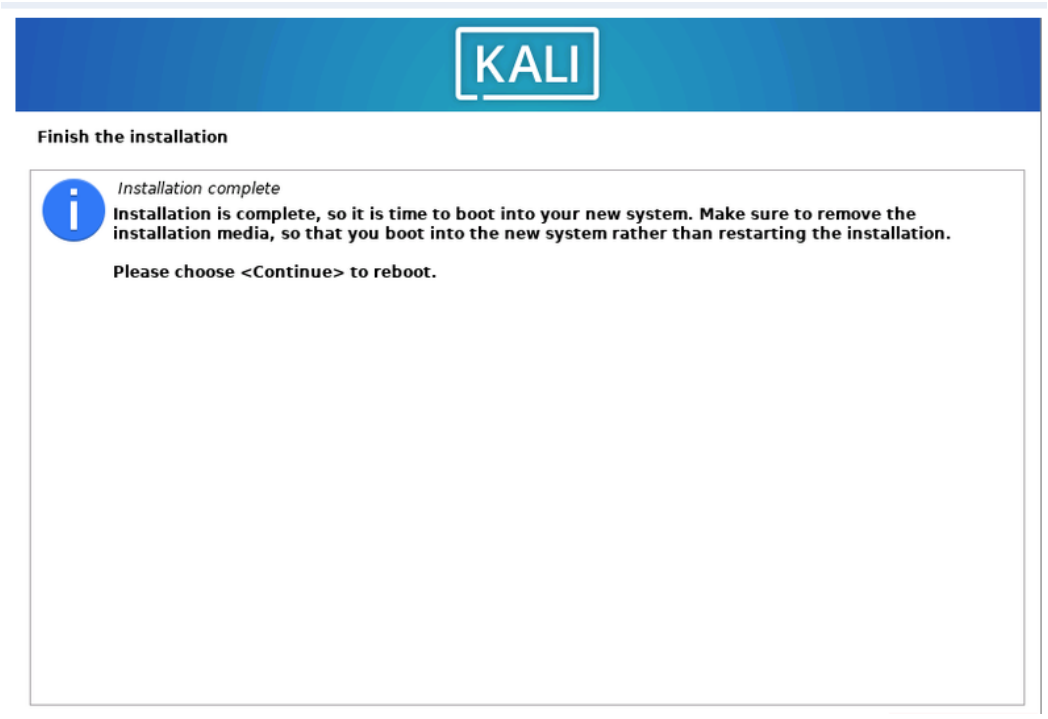
Step 30: Choose the boot loader device

Select /dev/sda and click **Continue**.



Step 31: Finish the installation

When you see *Installation complete*, click **Continue** to reboot into your new system. If prompted, the installation media is removed automatically in a VM; if the installer menu appears again, disconnect the ISO in the VM settings and restart.



Part 4 - First Boot

Step 32: Log in to Kali Linux

After the reboot, log in with the username and password you created. Kali Linux is now ready to use, with its collection of security tools available from the application menu.